

Some bases also have additional features such as heat profiles which lets users quickly change the amount of heat provided to the tip.

Brass sponge - When you solder, your tip will tend to oxidise and after considerable usage, it will turn black and not accept solder anymore. This happens more often in lead-free solders since there are impurities in the solder that build on the tip of your iron. This is where you use the sponge, to give your tip a good cleaning. Wet sponges, that were used previously, have become obsolete and brass sponges are the new standard since they do not damage the tip and clean the tip efficiently.

Soldering Accessories

Now that you have familiarised yourself with the soldering iron, let's discuss some of the common tools or accessories that are used during the process of soldering.

Solder Wick - This is essentially the eraser to soldering's pencil. When you are dealing with issues like jumpers or desoldering, solder wicks come in handy. Also known as the desoldering braid, the solder wick is made up of a thin copper wire braided together. Solder is soaked by the copper which lets users 'erase' excess solder.

Tip tinner - This is a chemical paste that can be used to clean the tip of your iron. There's a mild acid present in this that removes caked-up residue and prevents oxidation.

Solder Vacuum - This is a useful tool for removing solder that is left behind in through-holes when you are desoldering components.

Water Soluble Flux Pen - Flux is a chemical agent that helps in the flowing of lead-free solder. Flux pens allow you to take off unsightly components with liquid flux in order to get better-looking solder joints. Remember to clean and remove any excess water-soluble flux residue on the board.

With these tools and skills that have been discussed in the chapter, you should be more equipped to deal with electronics such as the dev boards we will elucidate in the next chapter. **d**